

■ RAMESH CHOPRA

All screens and devices seem to be on diet to get slim and trim. In particular, the mobile, the PC and the TV screens—the most important ones in our daily lives. And they are all getting well-connected to each other and the ‘cloud.’ The cloud here refers, of course, to the Internet. This is one of the clear messages I got at this year’s *Consumer Electronics Show*



Janet Galore, program manager of Microsoft, demonstrates their new ultra-thin, flexible monitor

at Las Vegas in the USA.

You have already seen much slimmer and lighter PCs introduced last year, starting with Mac's. Preference for thinner TVs is also well-known, although they cost hell of a lot at present for anyone to be able to afford one. I also notice preference for thin, sleek mobile phones when I look around—especially in international forums such as the CES.

Is it due to the global economic downturn that the manufacturers have started saving on the material cost? Of course, no! The reason is to make the devices look better as these become our lifestyle statements. The slim is the ‘in’ thing nowadays. This must have taken a while to register in the US where big was always considered to be better.

Microsoft

In place of Bill Gates, who has been giving keynote address almost regularly at CES, Steve Balmer, Microsoft's CEO, took the stage this year for the first time to show the shape of things to come from their end. As he disclosed, beta version of ‘Windows 7’ has just been launched worldwide. It can be downloaded from the Internet for checking, according to Steve. He showcased its salient features to the

audience.

“There is no turning back from the connected world,” said Steve. No matter what happens with the economy, or how long the recession lasts, the companies that continue to pursue advancement in technology will do much better than those who lag behind, he feels. Microsoft had invested \$8 billion in R&D last year alone for this purpose.

“There is so much opportunity ahead of us,” said Steve. First and foremost is the convergence of the three screens that people use every day—the PC, the phone and the TV. Microsoft's original aim was to put a PC on every desk. Today, a billion people already have PC. But that means there are five billion people who have never owned a PC. So we have a big task ahead of us to make computing more affordable.

There is also the challenge and opportunity for creating anytime, anywhere computing through the convergence of the PC, phone and TV, and their connectivity through the Internet. Soon smart phones will make up 50 per cent of the mobile phone market. Also, we shall soon see TV becoming more sophisticated and more connected, and the boundary between the PC and TV will dissolve.

In the next couple of years, accord-